

MEGAGEM

Rules & Reference

3–5 players (best with 4) · about 30 minutes · auctions, hidden information, market valuation

EDITOR'S NOTE The 30-minute listed time is accurate for players who have all played before. For new players, expect 45–60 minutes for each of the first two games, plus 5–10 minutes of explanation. Experienced players using a familiar value chart, not aiming for highly optimized play, can finish in 18–25 minutes.

COMPONENTS

- 30 Gem cards (green & blue backs)
- 25 Auction cards (green)
- 30 Mission cards (red)
- 5 Value Charts
- 80 coins (20 × '5', 60 × '1')

Gems

Five colors, six copies of each (copies are indistinguishable):

				
Yellow square-cut	Blue circle-cut	Purple triangle-cut	Pink pentagon-cut	Green oval-cut

Mission cards (red)

30 cards; 4 are used per game.

- 15 cards: every unique combination of two gems, once each (pairs included) - 5 points each.
- 10 cards: every unique combination of three gems, no pairs (e.g. no Yellow–Yellow–Green) - 10 points each.
- 5 cards: mystery-gem missions, one of each: any pair (5 pts) · any two pairs (15 pts) · three of a kind (10 pts) · three different gems (5 pts) · four different gems (10 pts).



Example mission cards

Auction cards (green)

25 cards; 9–21 are used per game (average about 16; 80% of games fall in 13–19).

1 Gem, ×12 2 Gems, ×5 Invest 5, ×2 Invest 10, ×2 Loan 10, ×2 Loan 20, ×2

Value charts

Each chart maps the **number of gems of a color revealed as information** to the **points per gem of that color** a player has purchased. One chart is used per game, applying to all five colors.

# revealed	A	B	C	D	E
0	0	20	0	20	0
1	4	16	2	18	4
2	8	12	5	15	10
3	12	8	9	11	18
4	16	4	14	6	6
5+	20	0	20	0	0

Chart A is linear and ascending: the more of a color is revealed, the more each copy is worth. Chart B is its descending mirror - scarcity pays. C and D bend those curves; E rewards hitting exactly three revealed and punishes overshooting.

RULES OF THE GAME

Basic structure

The game begins with about half the deck of gems in players' hands as **secret information**, and the other half as assets to be auctioned from the deck. Each player starts with some coins as liquid assets to bid and spend - significantly less than the average end-game value of the things to be bought. Each time a player wins an auction, they collect the purchased reward and reveal one gem from their secret information, placing it into the pool of **public information**.

End of the game and victory

The game ends when the last gem from the deck is purchased at auction. At that point the value of all gems, missions (a.k.a. achievements or jewelry), and loans/investments is calculated and converted to coins/points. The winner is the player with the most coins.

Caveats

WARNING Gems that start in a player's hand **are not in their possession**. They will not score at the end of the game even if still in hand. They are **exclusively information** - treat them as gems you know that someone else, not playing the game, owns, and has told you about.

WARNING Gems purchased at auction **do not contribute to the Value Chart**. The chart maps from the number of gems of a color in the **public information** to the value of gems **purchased at auction**. A gem you know was sold at auction is simply a gem you know is not secret information and will never appear as public information - nothing more.

Setup

1. Shuffle all three decks. Select a Value Chart for the game; for a first game, use Chart A. Charts B, C, D, and E are in ascending order of complexity.

EDITOR'S NOTE I recommend using chart E only by full consensus. Jumping from A to B or C, or from B or C to D, needs less care - but playing D with someone who has only played A is probably unwise and/or unfair.

2. Distribute coins and gem cards to each player as follows. Coins are public and remain so. Gem cards in hand (information gems) are private until the rules require them to be revealed.

Players	Coins each	Information gems each
3	35	5
4	25	4
5	20	3

3. Reveal four Mission cards (each displays a jewelry shape with 2–4 spots for gems and an associated point total). Put the rest of that deck away; it is not used again this game.
4. Place the remaining gem deck in the center and reveal the first two gems in a line leading away from the deck. Place the Auction deck in the center next to it. Reveal the first auction to begin the first round.

Auction round

Step 1 - Reveal the auction. A round begins when a card is revealed to determine what is at auction. It is one of three things:

Treasure (17 cards: 12 '1 Gem' and 5 '2 Gems'). The winner takes either the oldest of the two visible gems, or both, depending on the number. **They place the gem(s) face up in front of them** in their Collection - not hidden, not in hand. (A '2 Gems' auction with the deck empty and only one gem visible is treated as a '1 Gem' auction.) After this auction is won - **after the winner reveals a card** - the gems are replenished: the remaining visible gem (if any) moves away from the deck, then empty spaces are filled from the top of the deck.

Invest (4 cards: 2 '5 Coin Return' and 2 '10 Coin Return'). Worth the listed coins at the end of the game. The winner takes the card and additionally **places their bid on top of the card** rather than paying the bank. Those coins cannot be used for bids for the rest of the game, but they are returned at the end and count toward the player's score.

Loan (4 cards: 2 'Borrow 10 Coins' and 2 'Borrow 20 Coins'). Comes with coins from the bank as **liquid cash for bidding**, but is worth negative coins at the end of the game equal to the amount supplied. The bid is paid to the bank at the same time the borrowed coins come out. Important: **for loans, and loans only, you may bid more coins than you possess**, so long as you can pay the bid once you receive the loan. You may - and probably should - resolve the borrow as a net: e.g. *bid 6 for a loan of 20, take 14 coins, owe 20*, rather than taking 20 and then paying 6.

DESIGNER'S NOTE It is dangerous to bid yourself low on coins and become unable to bid later (until a loan comes up, if ever). Think carefully before excluding yourself from, potentially, all remaining auctions. After the game begins there is **no way to get more bidding coins** besides loans.

Step 2 - Bid. Each player secretly chooses a bid. When all players are ready, bids are revealed simultaneously. The highest bid wins and is paid to the bank (except for Investments, above). On a tie, go clockwise from the most recent auction winner; the first tied player on that arc wins. On the first auction of the game, settle ties with rock–paper–scissors.

EDITOR'S NOTE I prefer to break first-auction ties clockwise from the previous **game's** winner, or to randomize the 'most recent winner' before bidding. But it barely comes up.

To make bids, write them down and reveal at once, or conceal coins in a fist and reveal.

EDITOR'S NOTE Fastest method I've found: each player sticks up a thumb when ready, then on a count of "3, 2, 1..." everyone speaks their bid aloud simultaneously. If there's confusion - and often there will be - ask for a repeat. This is technically easier to cheat with, but in practice hard enough to get away with that it isn't rewarded. It keeps every player's coin stock fully visible and needs no paper. It cuts game time by about 10% in my experience.

Step 3 - Reveal information. The winner **takes the auction card** (regardless of type) and reveals one information gem from their hand, placing it in the public information display. This happens no matter what was auctioned: winning two gems reveals only one card, as does a loan or investment. All other players are now slightly better informed about likely gem values for final scoring.

Step 4 - Missions and replenishment. If the auction winner acquired gems and can complete a mission, they do so now: compare the gems in their Collection to each visible Mission's requirements. If the mission's group of gems is fully contained in their Collection, they take the mission and will score it at the end of the game; no other player may complete it. If they satisfy several missions at once, they take all of them. This is also when the visible gems are replenished from the gem deck: slide any visible gem away from the deck, then fill the gap(s) from the top of the deck.

Step 5 - Next round. Begin the next auction round at Step 1 - unless the gem deck is empty and the row of gems to be auctioned is also empty. In that case the game is over; proceed to scoring.

Scoring

When all gems have been auctioned off, every player with information gems still in hand reveals them.

EDITOR'S NOTE You may instead do this when the last gem is turned face up from the gem deck - though if more than one player still has gems in hand at that point, it reveals a small but potentially relevant amount of information.

Recoup all coins from your Investment cards. Add the values of missions and investments to your coin count, and subtract the values of loans. For gems, count the public information gems revealed of each color and use the Value Chart to determine the point value of each gem in your Collection.

EDITOR'S NOTE All gems are intended to use the same value chart. If you want to try the raw chaos of 'pink uses Chart A, purple B, yellow C, blue D, green E' or similar, please comment and tell me how it goes - but I expect it to be mostly incomprehensible.

Worked example (Chart C)

Carol has just finished a four-player game. She started with 25 coins; now she has two green gems, two pink, and one yellow in her Collection. In the public display there are three green gems, two pink, and four yellow. (All sixteen information gems have been revealed, so there are also five blue and two purple - these have no effect on her score.)

Color	# in display	Chart C value	# collected	Points
 Green	3	9	2	18
 Pink	2	5	2	10
 Yellow	4	14	1	14

That's $18 + 10 + 14 = 42$ **points from gems**. She also has 2 bidding coins remaining, took a loan of 10 coins, and completed the 'any two pairs of gems' mission worth 15 points. No investments. Her final score is $42 + 2 + 15 - 10 = 49$. Very well done!

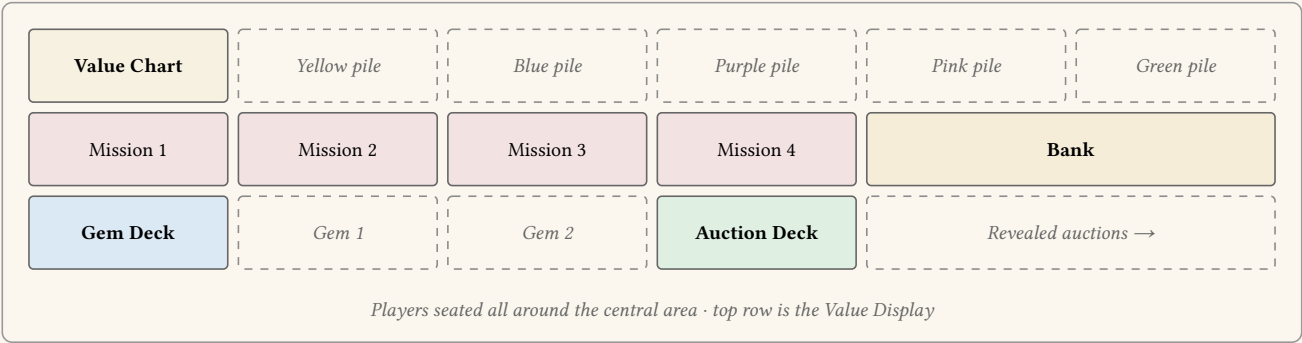
EDITOR'S NOTE In my experience that score would very likely win a four-player game with chart C or D. With charts A and B, good scores run 10–20% higher. Roughly doubling your starting money puts you in contention but is probably not quite enough to win - unless there were many loans and uncompleted missions, and few investments or high-scoring completed missions.

PHYSICAL LAYOUT

Below, 'left' and 'right' are just suggestions; mirror them if that's more convenient.

Designer's suggestion

Create a row of six spots with the **Value Chart** at one side; as information gems are revealed, pile them by color in the five remaining spots. This is the **Value Display**. Below it, a second row holds the four **Mission cards** and the **Bank**. Below that, a third row: the **Gem Deck** at the left with space for two gem cards to its right, then the **Auction Deck**, with revealed auction cards going to its right. **Seat the players around this central play area.**



Editor's suggestion

This takes somewhat more space than the designer's suggestion but smooths play noticeably. It makes a clearer separation between the value display and the players' collections, and puts the text where it is most needed, most legibly. I don't think it lowers playtime (theoretically maybe 2–3%), but it does lower the error rate with new players.

Seat the players at one side of the table. For example, at a square table seating two per side, put two on one side and one each around the corner from it. Call the side the players are concentrated around 'down.' Place the **Bank** centrally between the players. Place the **Auction Deck** near the bank, on the left side and slightly above it, leaving space **below the auction deck**, on the left side, for a revealed **auction card**. Above that, place the four **Mission cards**, the **Value Chart**, and the **Gem Deck** - value chart in the middle, gem deck opposite the auction deck (so on the right), with space **below the gem deck** for **two gem cards**. Above all of that, furthest from the players, make the row of five spaces for the **Value Display**.

